

husband's estate. Divorce, which is an important indicator of women's rights, was common among upper-class Anglo-Saxon women. Divorce laws also granted women full custody of their children. Women's roles in this period were symbolized by girdle-hangers, many of which have been found in Anglo-Saxon female graves. These were long, distinctive, key-shaped pieces of metal that hung from women's girdles (or belts). They were not actually keys, but represented the woman's control of her household.

The Norman Conquest changed everything. Under William the Conqueror, land-holding was linked to a promise of military service to the crown, so he and his successors preferred that land be held by men and women's property rights were taken away. Women's property came to be controlled

by their husbands, and widows wanting to retain ownership of their lands had to pay a fine to the king and seek his approval. This loss of rights lasted hundreds of years, and it was not until the 19th century that women in England regained independent property rights.



BIOGRAPHY

ÆTHELFÆD

The oldest daughter of Alfred the Great, Æthelflæd was born around 870 and later married Ethelred, the ruler of Mercia. The kingdom was bordered by Vikings to the north, leading to constant warfare. Unusually for the time, Æthelflæd became involved in governing Mercia, and when her husband died in 911 she became the sole ruler. She launched several campaigns to take back the lands under Danish control, but died in 918 before completing the reconquest.



◀ Working companions

Anglo-Saxon women were mainly responsible for spinning yarn, weaving cloth, and embroidery. In communal weaving houses women could work and socialize at the same time.